



The Arabian Desert

Asia's largest desert, shared among nine nations, contained within a ring of mountains, and home to one of the largest continuous expanses of sand on Earth



Covering 900,000 square miles (2.3 million square km), the Arabian Desert is so large that it spans almost the entire Arabian Peninsula. The bulk of it lies within Saudi Arabia, but it also extends southwest into Yemen, southeast into Oman, east along the Persian Gulf into the United Arab Emirates and Qatar, northeast into Kuwait and Iraq, and northwest into Jordan, just nudging into the tip of Egypt.

Region of extremes

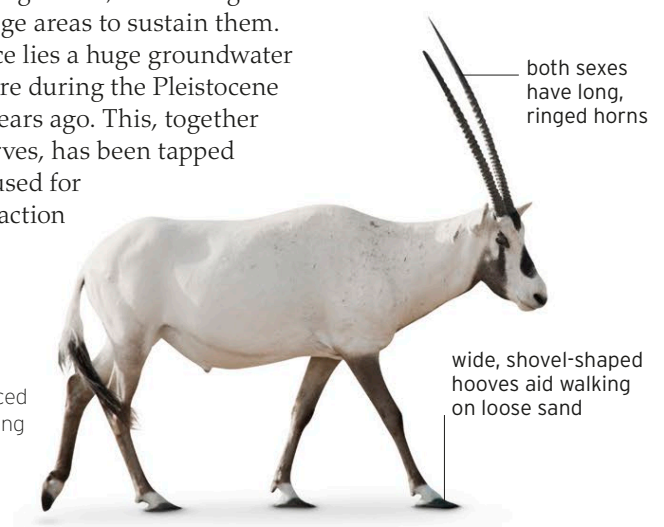
With vast stretches of sand in the south, gravel or salt-encrusted plains (*sabkha*s) in the east, volcanic fields to the west, and temperatures ranging from 122°F (50°C) on summer days to below freezing on winter nights, this environment at first seems too harsh for survival. However, a surprising number of creatures live here, particularly insects such as locusts and dung beetles, as well as spiders and scorpions. These serve

as food for many snakes and lizards, while mammals, including jerboas, goats, and gazelles, find enough vegetation in oases and fringe areas to sustain them.

Beneath the desert surface lies a huge groundwater reserve that was trapped here during the Pleistocene Epoch, 2.6 million–11,700 years ago. This, together with the area's vast oil reserves, has been tapped in recent years: the former used for irrigation, the latter for extraction of petroleum products.

► DESERT SURVIVOR

Once extinct in the wild, the rare Arabian oryx has been reintroduced and now roams the desert, foraging on grasses and roots. Its brilliant white coat reflects the worst of the desert Sun's heat.



both sexes have long, ringed horns

wide, shovel-shaped hooves aid walking on loose sand